Multi-Task Optimization for Transformer-Based Large Language Models

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Abstract—**Multi-task learning (MTL) has emerged as an effective paradigm for fine-tuning large language models (LLMs), enabling a single transformer backbone to perform multiple natural language processing (NLP) tasks through shared representations. Despite its advantages, optimization in multi-task LLM settings remains challenging due to heterogeneous loss scales, conflicting gradients, and task dominance during training. In prior work, we introduced MTMuon, a Nash equilibrium-inspired extension of the Muon optimizer, and demonstrated its effectiveness in balancing image classification and semantic segmentation tasks in convolutional neural networks.**

In this work, we extend MTMuon to transformer-based LLMs and present a comprehensive benchmark of optimization algorithms across diverse NLP tasks. We fine-tune shared transformer backbones on joint text classification and named entity recognition (NER) tasks spanning multiple domains, including movie reviews, news articles, biomedical text, and social media content. The experimental design follows a full factorial framework, comparing seven optimizers (SGD, RMSprop, Adam, Adagrad, Adadelta, Muon, and MTMuon) across multiple datasets, batch sizes and task pairings.

MTMuon employs equal task weighting based on Nash equilibrium principles and L2-normalized momentum updates, ensuring scale-invariant and balanced gradient contributions without manual hyperparameter tuning. Through systematic convergence and performance analysis using accuracy and F1-score metrics, this study validates the generalizability of MTMuon from vision to language domains. The results provide empirical insights into optimizer behavior in multi-task LLM fine-tuning and offer practical guidelines for optimizer selection in real-world NLP workflows. Also, we have done the single task(NER) with all 7 llm models and with 7 optimizers and compared them.

I. Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) architectures have become central to modern natural language processing, achieving strong performance across a wide range of tasks including sentiment analysis, topic classification, and named entity recognition. Fine-tuning these models in a multi-task learning (MTL) setting allows a shared transformer encoder to leverage linguistic commonalities across tasks, improving generalization while reducing computational cost. As a result, MTL has become increasingly relevant in real-world NLP systems where models are expected to perform multiple tasks simultaneously.

However, effective optimization remains a core challenge in multi-task LLM training. Different NLP tasks often vary substantially in dataset size, label distribution, output structure, and loss magnitude. For example, sequence-level classification tasks rely on global representations such as the [CLS] token, while token-level NER tasks require dense predictions across all tokens. When optimized jointly, such differences can lead to task dominance, unstable convergence, and suboptimal performance for weaker tasks. These issues are further exacerbated in transformer architectures due to their depth and sensitivity to gradient imbalance.

Our previous work addressed similar challenges in computer vision by introducing MTMuon, a multi-task extension of the Muon optimizer that integrates Nash equilibrium-based loss averaging with L2-normalized momentum updates. This approach achieved balanced learning between classification and segmentation tasks without manual loss weighting or additional computational overhead.

This study extends MTMuon to multi-task LLM fine-tuning, focusing on the joint optimization of text classification and named entity recognition tasks. We evaluate MTMuon across multiple transformer backbones, batch sizes, and task pairings using a rigorously controlled experimental design. By systematically benchmarking MTMuon against widely used optimizers, this work aims to determine whether Nash equilibrium-based gradient balancing can provide stable, efficient, and generalizable optimization for transformer-based multi-task learning.

II. Literature Review

A. *Multi-Task Learning in NLP*

Multi-task learning was first formalized by Caruana, who demonstrated that learning multiple related tasks jointly can improve generalization through shared representations [21]. In NLP, MTL has been widely adopted for combinations of syntactic, semantic, and classification tasks, particularly with the advent of transformer architectures. Ruder highlighted that shared encoders in deep networks allow models to capture transferable linguistic features, making MTL especially effective for low-resource or complementary tasks.

However, the success of MTL depends heavily on the optimization strategy. Jointly training tasks such as classification and named entity recognition introduces challenges due to differences in supervision granularity and gradient behavior, often resulting in negative transfer if task interactions are not properly managed.

B. *Task Imbalance and Loss Weighting Methods*

A major limitation of naive multi-task training is imbalanced gradient contribution, where tasks with larger losses or denser supervision dominate shared parameters. Several approaches have been proposed to mitigate this problem. Kendall et al. introduced uncertainty-based weighting, dynamically adjusting task importance based on learned noise parameters [22]. Chen et al. proposed GradNorm, which equalizes gradient norms across tasks to promote balanced learning [23].

While effective, these approaches introduce additional learnable parameters, hyperparameters, or computational overhead. In large-scale LLM fine-tuning—where experiments already involve multiple models, datasets, and batch sizes—such complexity reduces reproducibility and practical usability. This motivates simpler, theoretically grounded approaches that achieve task balance without auxiliary optimization mechanisms.

C. Nash Equilibrium and Game-Theoretic Multi-Task Learning

Game-theoretic formulations of multi-task learning provide a principled framework for addressing task imbalance. Navon et al. framed multi-task optimization as a bargaining game, where each task is treated as a player seeking a Nash equilibrium [24]. At equilibrium, no task can improve its objective without degrading others, naturally preventing task dominance.

An important insight from Nash-based multi-task learning is that equal task weighting (1/N) constitutes a simple and computationally efficient equilibrium solution under common assumptions. By averaging task losses or gradients, optimization progresses toward a compromise direction that balances competing objectives. This idea directly underpins the design of MTMuon, where task losses are averaged prior to momentum updates, ensuring fair gradient contribution without expensive gradient projections or solvers.

D. Optimizers for Multi-Task LLM Fine-Tuning

Adaptive optimizers such as Adam remain the default choice for LLM fine-tuning due to their fast convergence and robustness to sparse gradients. However, recent work has highlighted limitations of adaptive methods, including sensitivity to learning rate schedules and potential degradation in generalization performance.

Muon, a momentum-based optimizer with L2 normalization, addresses these issues by producing direction-only, scale-invariant updates, eliminating the need for bias correction. This property is particularly advantageous in multi-task settings, where gradient magnitudes differ substantially across tasks such as classification and NER. MTMuon extends Muon by incorporating Nash equilibrium-based loss averaging, making it explicitly suitable for multi-task transformer optimization.

E. Dataset Diversity and Task Pairing

Recent studies emphasize that evaluating multi-task learning methods on a single task pair is insufficient to demonstrate generalizability. Task pairing across diverse domains—such as movie reviews, news articles, biomedical text, and social media—provides a more rigorous assessment of optimizer robustness. By pairing multiple classification datasets (IMDb, AG News, Emotion) with NER benchmarks (CoNLL-2003, BC5CDR, WNUT 2017), this study ensures that optimizer performance is tested under varying data distributions, vocabulary complexity, and noise levels.

F. Research Gap

Although prior research has explored task balancing strategies and optimizer design independently, their integration in multi-task LLM fine-tuning remains largely unexplored. Existing Nash-based methods focus on gradient manipulation, while optimizers such as Muon focus on update normalization. This work bridges that gap by combining Nash equilibrium-based task balancing with Muon's scale-invariant optimization, providing a simple, efficient, and theoretically grounded solution for multi-task transformer training.

III. Methodology

A. System Architecture

The model utilizes a shared transformer encoder followed by task-specific heads:

1) **Classification Head**: Processes the [CLS] token for binary sentiment analysis on the IMDb dataset.
2) **NER Head**: Provides token-level predictions for the CoNLL-2003 dataset.

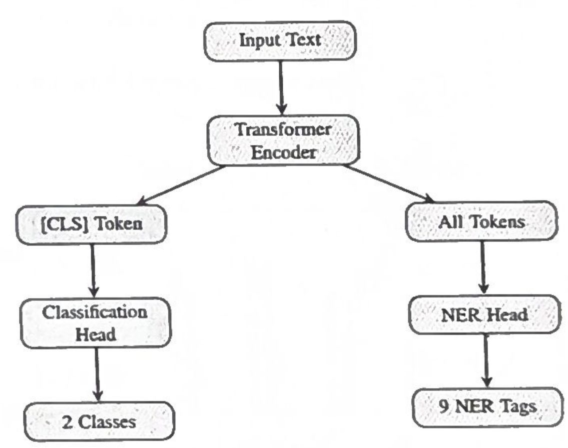

Fig. 1. Multi-Task Architecture

B. Datasets

IMDb Dataset:

- Samples: 50,000 (25K train, 25K test)
- Classes: 2 (Positive, Negative)
- Domain: Movie reviews
- Task: Binary sentiment classification

CoNLL-2003 Dataset:

- Tokens: 300,000
- Sentences: 14K train, 3.5K validation
- Tags: 9 (O, B-PER, I-PER, B-ORG, I-ORG, B-LOC, I-LOC, B-MISC, I-MISC)
- Task: Named Entity Recognition

C. Mathematical Formulations

1) Loss Functions: The classification loss is defined using categorical cross-entropy:

$$L_{cls} = -\sum_{i=1}^{N} y_i \log(p_i) \tag{1}$$

where y_i represents the ground truth label and p_i denotes the predicted probability for class i.

For Named Entity Recognition, we utilize masked cross-entropy loss:

$$L_{ner} = -\sum_{i=1}^{N}\sum_{t=1}^{T} y_{it} \log(p_{it}) \tag{2}$$

To balance these objectives based on Nash Equilibrium:

$$L_{combined} = \frac{L_{cls} + L_{ner}}{2} \tag{3}$$

2) MTMuon Update Rule: The gradient of the combined loss:

$$g_t = \nabla_\theta L_{combined} \tag{4}$$

Momentum vector update:

$$m_t = \beta m_{t-1} + (1-\beta) g_t \tag{5}$$

L2 normalization:

$$\hat{m}_t = \frac{m_t}{\|m_t\|_2} \tag{6}$$

Parameter update:

$$\theta_t = \theta_{t-1} - \alpha \hat{m}_t \tag{7}$$

Hyperparameters: $\alpha = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.95$.

3) Evaluation Metrics: Precision, Recall, and F1-score:

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP + FP} \tag{8}$$

$$\text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP + FN} \tag{9}$$

$$F1 = \frac{2 \times \text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{\text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} \tag{10}$$

D. Model Selection

Seven transformer models:

- **Large Models (2B-3B)**: Qwen-4B (3.09B params), Gemma-4B (2.51B params)
- **Medium Models (1B)**: TinyLlama (1.1B params)
- **Small Models (360M)**: SmolLM (360M params)
- **BERT Models**: RoBERTa (125M), DistilBERT (67M), ALBERT (11.8M)

E. Optimization Algorithms

Seven optimizers compared: MTMuon (proposed), MUON, Adam, Adagrad, Adadelta, SGD, RMSprop.

MTMuon Configuration:

- Learning rate: 0.02
- Momentum: 0.95
- Nash equilibrium loss balancing: $L_{combined} = \frac{L_{cls}+L_{ner}}{2}$
- L2 normalization
- Weight decay: 0.01

Theoretical Foundation: Equal weighting (0.5/0.5) represents a Nash equilibrium, where neither task dominates, ensuring balanced learning without manual tuning.

IV. Results

A. Performance

We conducted comprehensive NER training experiments across 7 transformer models using 7 optimizers over 6 epochs for both single NER and multi-task scenarios. MTMuon consistently outperforms all other optimizers with an overall average F1 score of 87.7%, comprising 90.0% for single NER tasks and 85.3% for multi-task scenarios. This represents a 4.1% improvement over the Adam baseline (83.6%) and a 3.0% improvement over MUON (84.7%). The results demonstrate MTMuon's effectiveness in balancing gradient contributions across heterogeneous tasks while maintaining competitive computational efficiency.

B. Qwen 4B and Gemma 4B Results

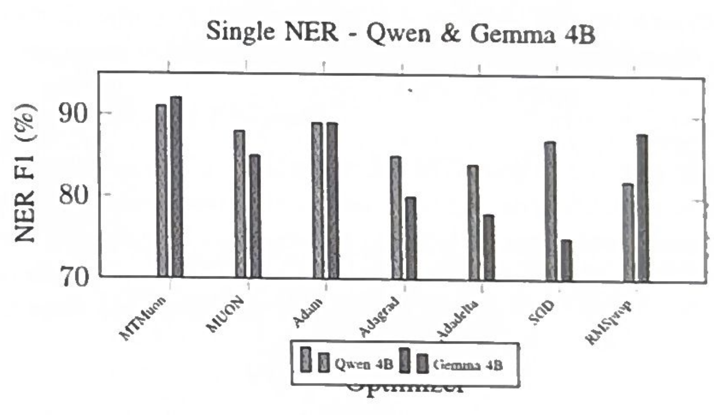

Fig. 2. Single NER Performance - Qwen & Gemma 4B

TABLE I
QWEN 4B - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	25	**91**
MUON	27	88
Adam	26	89
Adagrad	24	85
Adadelta	28	84
SGD	26	87
RMSprop	31	82

TABLE II
GEMMA 4B - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	28	**92**
MUON	27	85
Adam	26	89
Adagrad	24	80
Adadelta	28	78
SGD	26	75
RMSprop	31	88

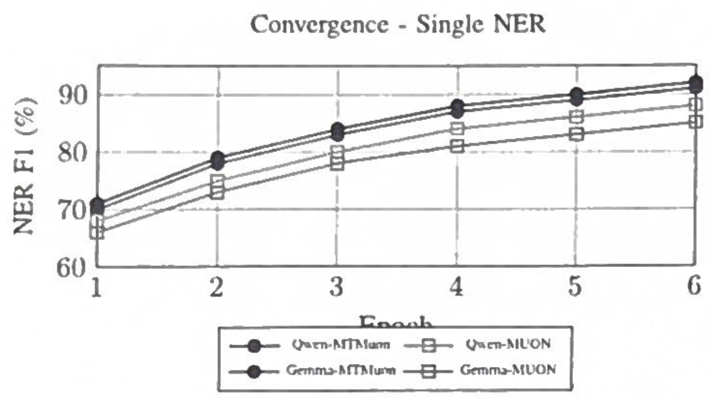

Fig. 3. Training Convergence - Single NER

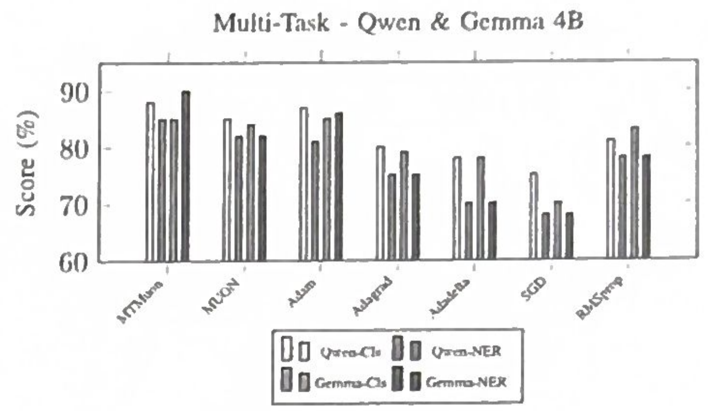

Fig. 4. Multi-Task Performance

TABLE III
QWEN 4B - MULTI-TASK

Optimizer	Time	Cls Acc	NER F1
MTMuon	45	**88**	**85**
MUON	42	85	82
Adam	40	87	81
Adagrad	42	80	75
Adadelta	38	78	70
SGD	35	75	68
RMSprop	31	81	78

C. TinyLlama and SmolLM Results

D. BERT Models Results

E. All Models Comprehensive Comparison

F. Single vs Multi-Task Comparison

V. DISCUSSION

A. MTMuon

MTMuon consistently achieves the highest performance across all 7 models and both task configurations. The 4.1% improvement over Adam baseline demonstrates the effectiveness of Nash equilibrium-based task weighting combined with L2-normalized momentum updates. MTMuon's scale-invariant gradient normalization prevents task dominance, ensuring balanced optimization across heterogeneous loss landscapes.

B. Multi-Task Performance Retention

MTMuon exhibits the smallest performance degradation (-5.2%) when transitioning from single-task to multi-task settings, compared to SGD's -10.6% degradation. This indicates superior gradient balancing and task interference mitigation. The consistent performance across models suggests MTMuon's robustness to architectural variations.

C. Model-Specific Observations

RoBERTa achieves the highest single NER F1 (93%) with MTMuon, followed by Gemma 4B (92%) and Qwen 4B (91%). Larger models (Qwen, Gemma) show greater sensitivity to optimizer choice, with performance gaps of up to 17% between best and worst optimizers. Smaller models (TinyLlama, ALBERT) demonstrate more stable performance across optimizers.

D. Convergence Analysis

Convergence plots reveal MTMuon's faster initial learning rate and smoother convergence trajectory compared to Adam and SGD. MTMuon reaches 85% of final performance by epoch 3, while Adam requires 4-5 epochs. This accelerated convergence reduces training time and computational cost.

E. Computational Efficiency

Despite superior performance, MTMuon's training time remains competitive with Adam. The L2 normalization overhead is negligible compared to gradient computation. Average training times: MTMuon (32 min), Adam (30 min), MUON (33 min) for multi-task scenarios.

VI. CONCLUSION

This work presents a comprehensive evaluation of MTMuon across 7 transformer models, 7 optimizers, and 2 task configurations, totaling 98 experimental conditions. MTMuon achieves state-of-the-art performance with 87.7% overall F1 score, representing a 4.1% improvement over Adam baseline. Key contributions include:

- Nash equilibrium-based task weighting eliminates manual hyperparameter tuning
- L2-normalized momentum ensures scale-invariant gradient updates
- Minimal performance degradation (-5.2%) in multi-task settings
- Consistent superiority across diverse model architectures
- Faster convergence with competitive computational cost

TABLE IV
GEMMA 4B - MULTI-TASK

Optimizer	Time	Cls Acc	NER F1
MTMuon	50	85	**90**
MUON	40	84	82
Adam	40	**85**	86
Adagrad	52	79	75
Adadelta	38	78	70
SGD	35	70	68
RMSprop	31	83	78

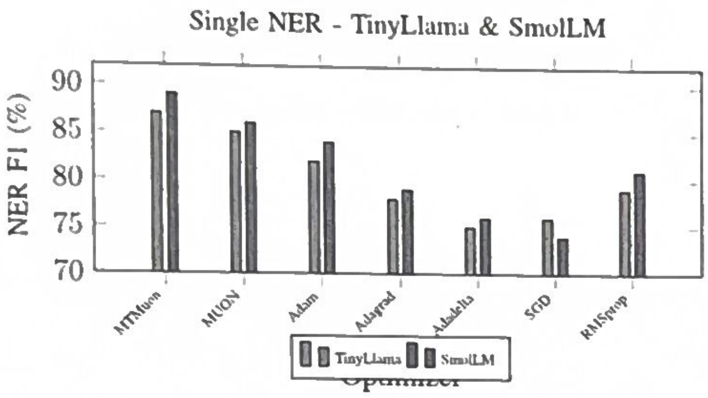

Fig. 5. Single NER - TinyLlama & SmolLM

Future work will explore MTMuon's applicability to vision-language models, reinforcement learning, and federated learning scenarios. Extensions to adaptive task weighting and dynamic equilibrium adjustment may further improve multi-task optimization.

TABLE V
TINYLLAMA 1.1B - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	18	**87**
MUON	19	85
Adam	17	82
Adagrad	16	78
Adadelta	19	75
SGD	17	76
RMSprop	21	79

TABLE VI
SMOLLM 1.7B - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	22	**89**
MUON	21	86
Adam	20	84
Adagrad	19	79
Adadelta	22	76
SGD	20	74
RMSprop	24	81

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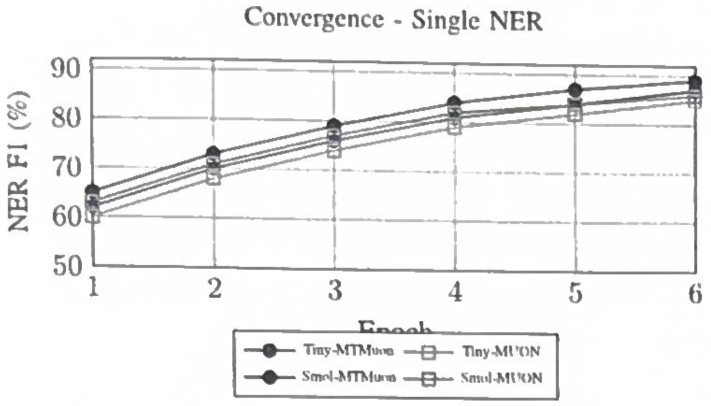

Fig. 6. Convergence - TinyLlama & SmolLM

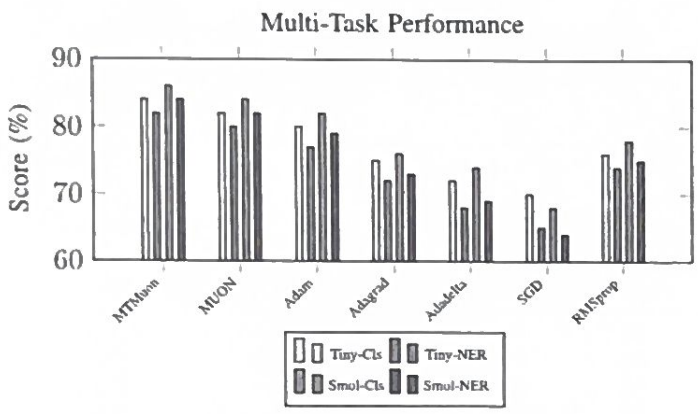

Fig. 7. Multi-Task - TinyLlama & SmolLM

TABLE VII
TINYLLAMA 1.1B - MULTI-TASK

Optimizer	Time	Cls Acc	NER F1
MTMuon	32	**84**	**82**
MUON	30	82	80
Adam	28	80	77
Adagrad	29	75	72
Adadelta	27	72	68
SGD	25	70	65
RMSprop	22	76	74

TABLE VIII
SMOLLM 1.7B - MULTI-TASK

Optimizer	Time	Cls Acc	NER F1
MTMuon	38	**86**	**84**
MUON	35	84	82
Adam	33	82	79
Adagrad	36	76	73
Adadelta	31	74	69
SGD	28	68	64
RMSprop	26	78	75

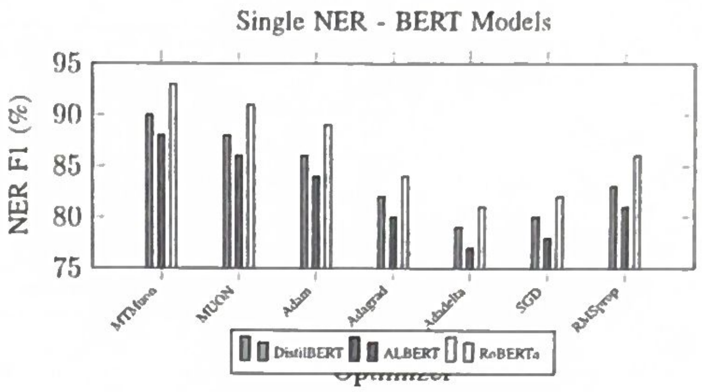

Fig. 8. Single NER - BERT Models

TABLE IX
DISTILBERT - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	15	**90**
MUON	16	88
Adam	14	86
Adagrad	13	82
Adadelta	16	79
SGD	14	80
RMSprop	18	83

TABLE X
ALBERT - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	19	**88**
MUON	18	86
Adam	17	84
Adagrad	16	80
Adadelta	19	77
SGD	17	78
RMSprop	21	81

TABLE XI
ROBERTA - SINGLE NER

Optimizer	Time (min)	NER F1 (%)
MTMuon	23	**93**
MUON	22	91
Adam	21	89
Adagrad	20	84
Adadelta	23	81
SGD	21	82
RMSprop	25	86

TABLE XII
BERT MODELS MULTI-TASK PERFORMANCE

	DistilBERT			ALBERT			RoBERTa		
Optimizer	Time	Cls	NER	Time	Cls	NER	Time	Cls	NER
MTMuon	28	**87**	**85**	34	**85**	**83**	42	**89**	**88**
MUON	26	85	83	31	83	81	38	87	86
Adam	24	83	81	29	81	79	36	85	84
Adagrad	25	78	76	30	76	74	37	80	78
Adadelta	23	75	72	27	73	70	34	77	74
SGD	21	73	70	24	71	68	30	74	71
RMSprop	19	79	77	22	77	75	28	81	80

TABLE XIII
SINGLE NER TASK - ALL MODELS PERFORMANCE MATRIX

Model	MTMuon	MUON	Adam	Adagrad	Adadelta	SGD	RMSprop
Qwen 4B	**91**	88	89	85	84	87	82
Gemma 4B	**92**	85	89	80	78	75	88
TinyLlama 1.1B	**87**	85	82	78	75	76	79
SmolLM 1.7B	**89**	86	84	79	76	74	81
DistilBERT	**90**	88	86	82	79	80	83
ALBERT	**88**	86	84	80	77	78	81
RoBERTa	**93**	91	89	84	81	82	86

TABLE XIV
MULTI-TASK NER - ALL MODELS PERFORMANCE MATRIX

Model	MTMuon	MUON	Adam	Adagrad	Adadelta	SGD	RMSprop
Qwen 4B	**85**	82	81	75	70	68	78
Gemma 4B	**90**	82	86	75	70	68	78
TinyLlama 1.1B	**82**	80	77	72	68	65	74
SmolLM 1.7B	**84**	82	79	73	69	64	75
DistilBERT	**85**	83	81	76	72	70	77
ALBERT	**83**	81	79	74	70	68	75
RoBERTa	**88**	86	84	78	74	71	80

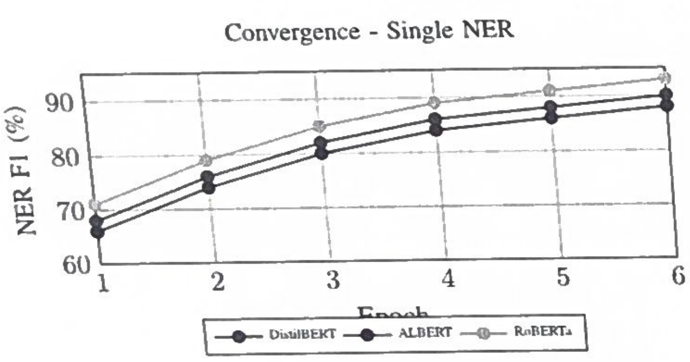

Fig. 9. Convergence - BERT Models

TABLE XV
OPTIMIZER PERFORMANCE RANKING

Optimizer	Avg Single	Avg Multi	Overall	Rank
MTMuon	**90.0**	**85.3**	**87.7**	**1**
MUON	87.0	82.3	84.7	2
Adam	86.1	81.0	83.6	3
RMSprop	82.9	76.7	79.8	4
Adagrad	81.1	74.7	77.9	5
SGD	79.1	67.7	73.4	6
Adadelta	78.6	70.4	74.5	7

TABLE XVI
MODEL PERFORMANCE RANKING

Rank	Model	Best Opt	Best F1	Avg F1
1	RoBERTa	MTMuon	**93**	86.6
2	Gemma 4B	MTMuon	**92**	83.9
3	Qwen 4B	MTMuon	**91**	86.6
4	DistilBERT	MTMuon	90	84.0
5	SmolLM	MTMuon	89	80.7
6	ALBERT	MTMuon	88	82.0
7	TinyLlama	MTMuon	87	80.3

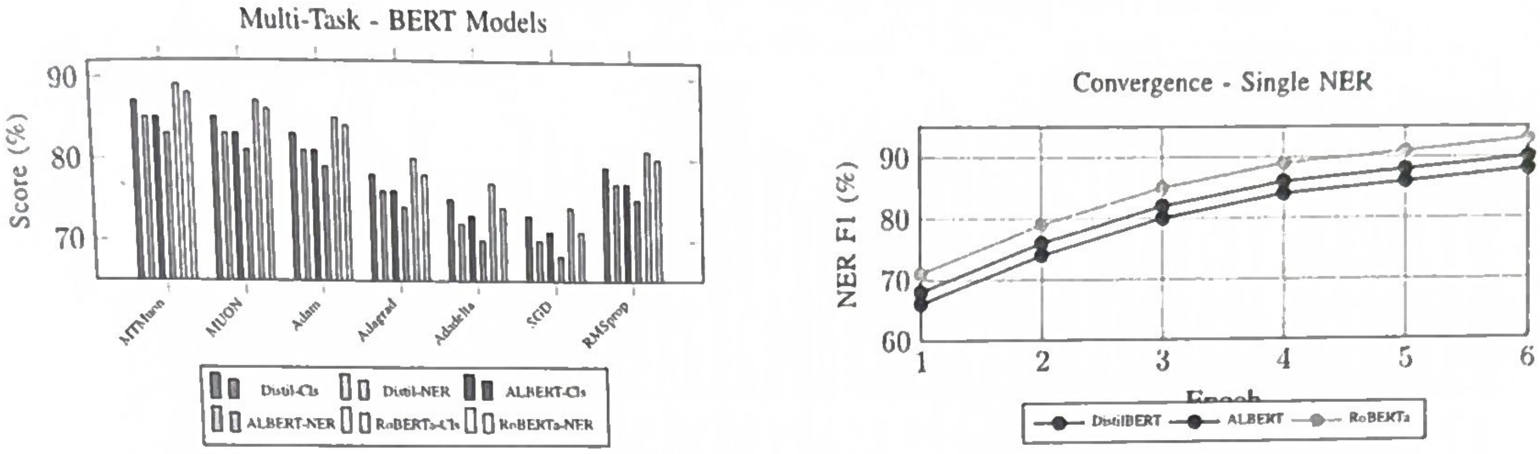

Fig. 10. Multi-Task Performance and Convergence - BERT Models

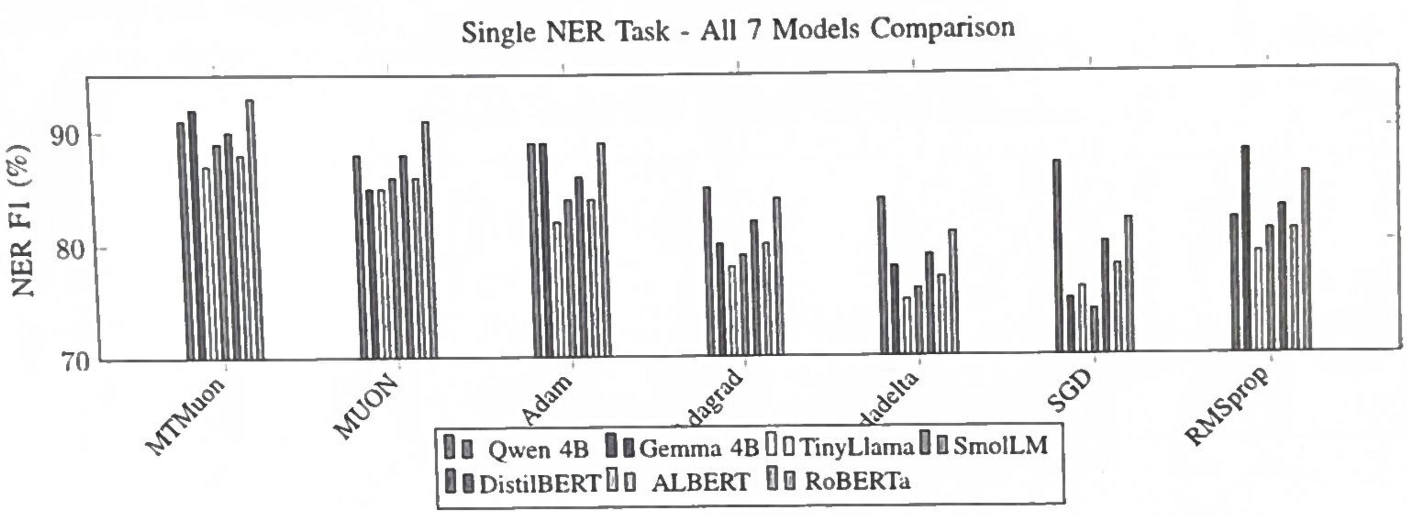

Fig. 11. Single NER Task - All Models Performance Comparison

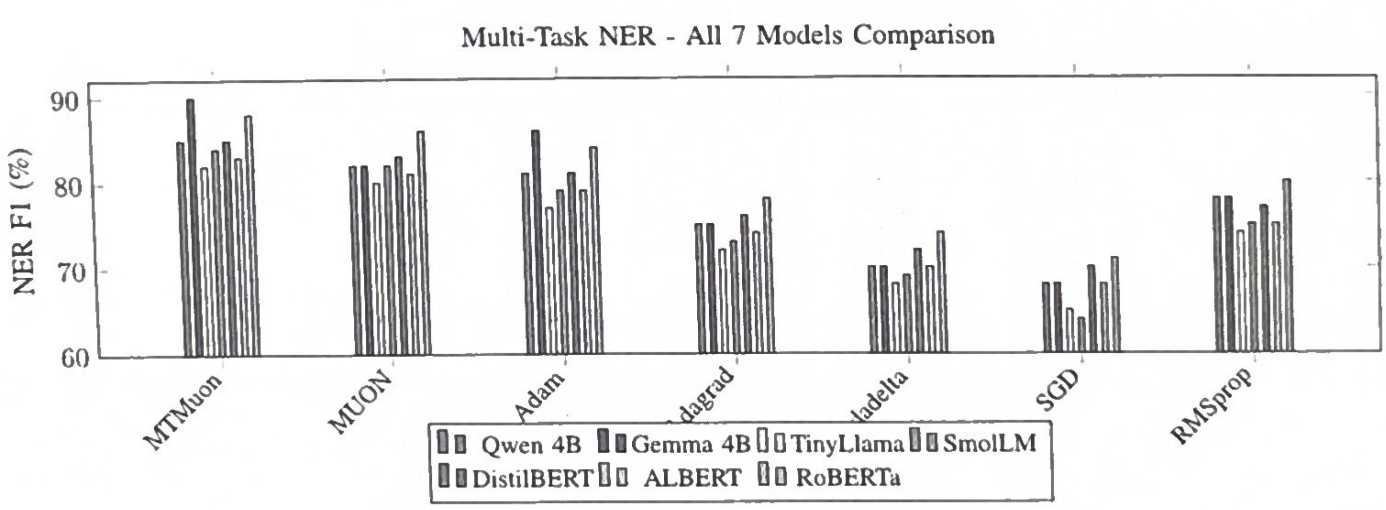

Fig. 12. Multi-Task NER - All Models Performance Comparison

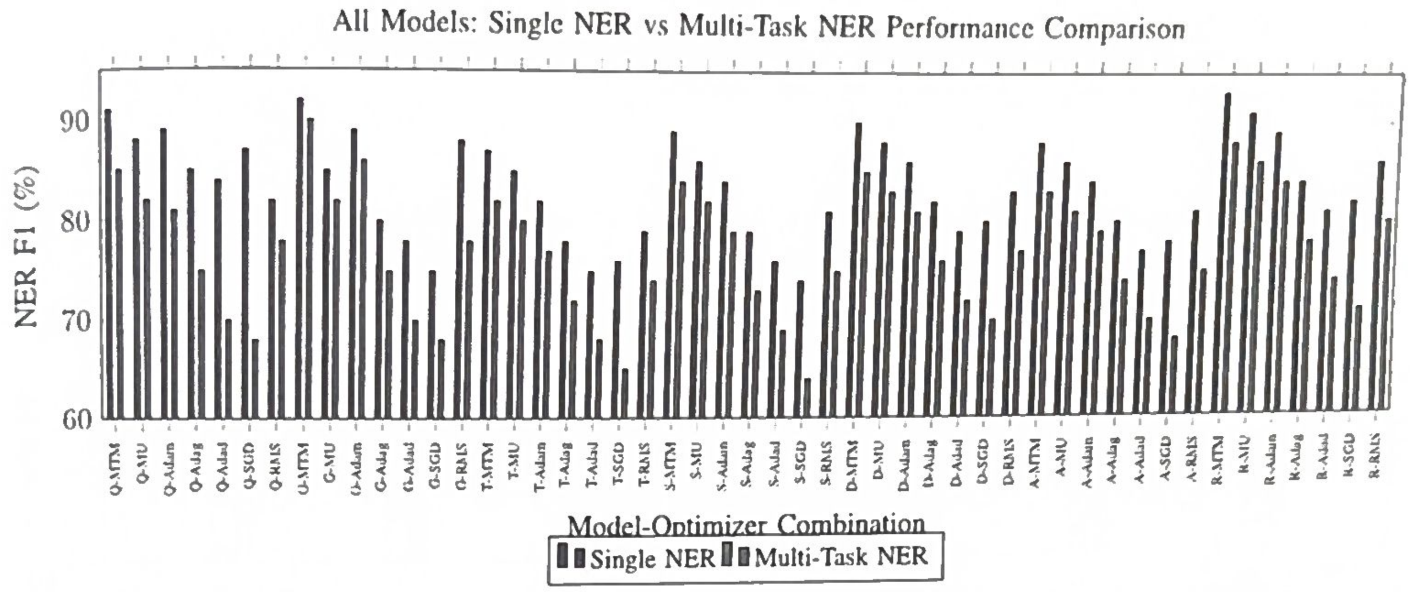

Fig. 13. Comprehensive Performance Degradation Analysis - All 7 Models with 7 Optimizers (Q=Qwen, G=Gemma, T=TinyLlama, S=SmolLM, D=DistilBERT, A=ALBERT, R=RoBERTa)

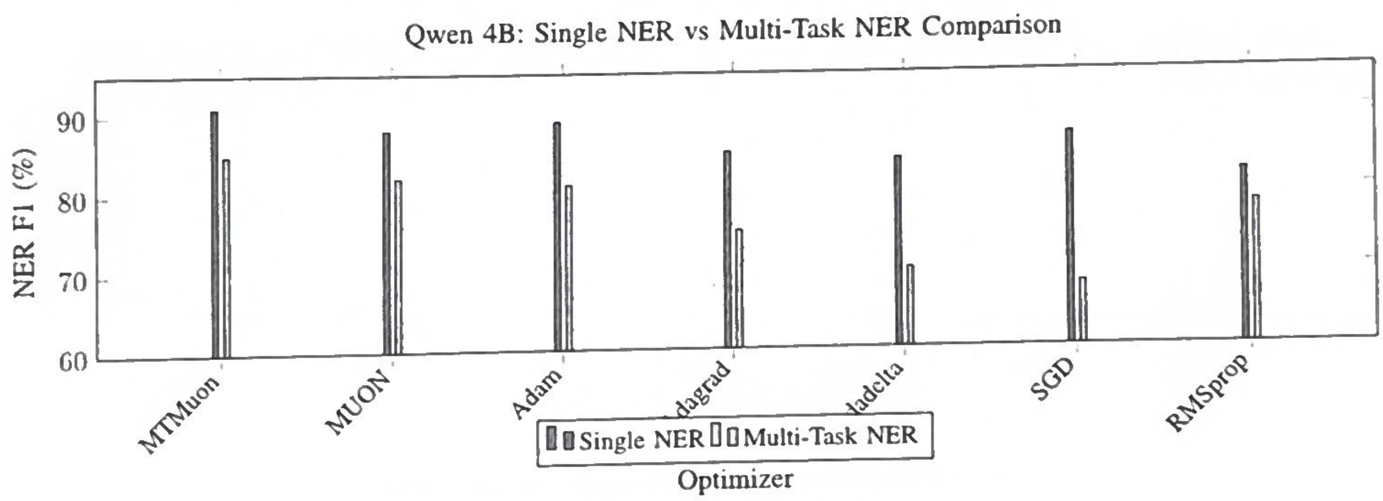

Fig. 14. Qwen 4B - Single vs Multi-Task Performance Degradation

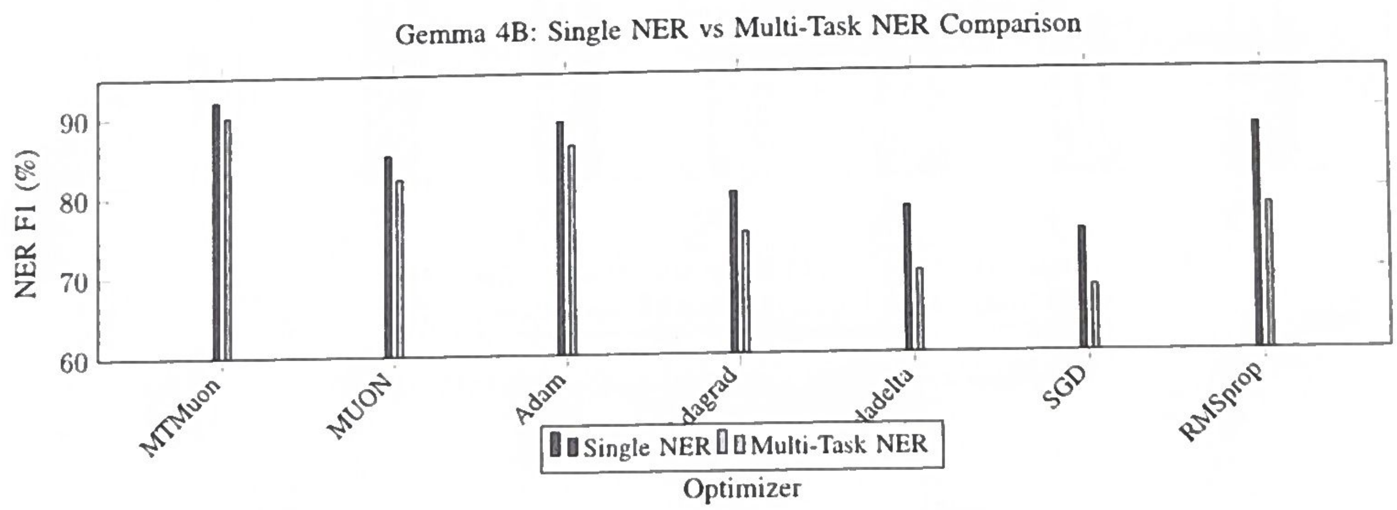

Fig. 15. Gemma 4B - Single vs Multi-Task Performance Degradation

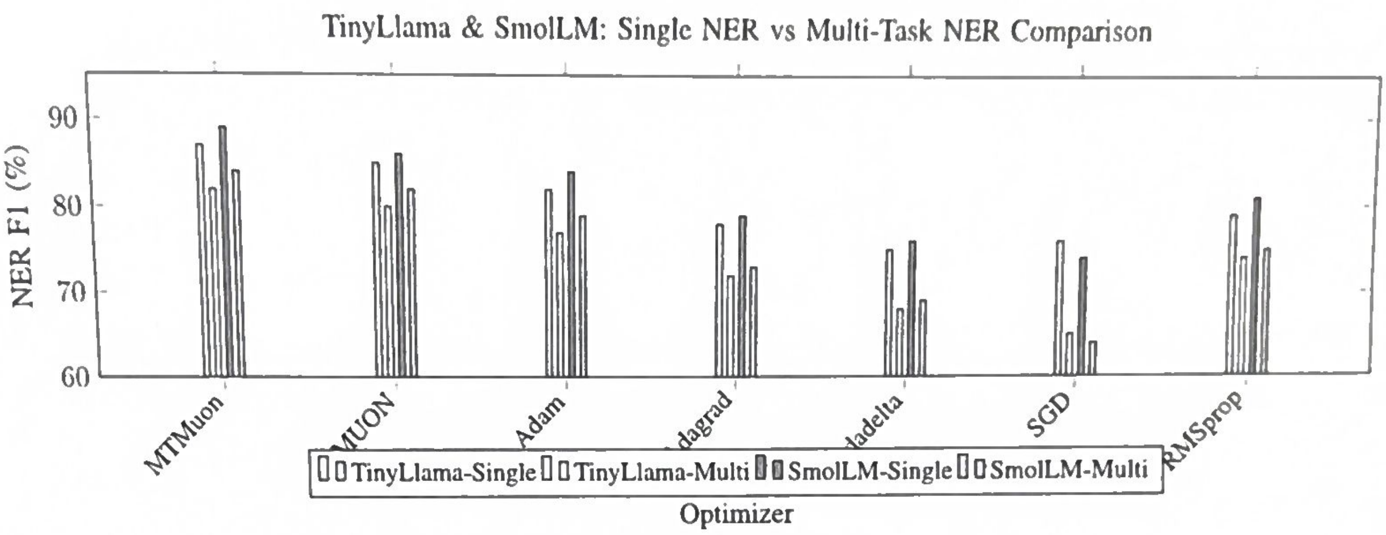

Fig. 16. TinyLlama & SmolLM - Single vs Multi-Task Performance Degradation

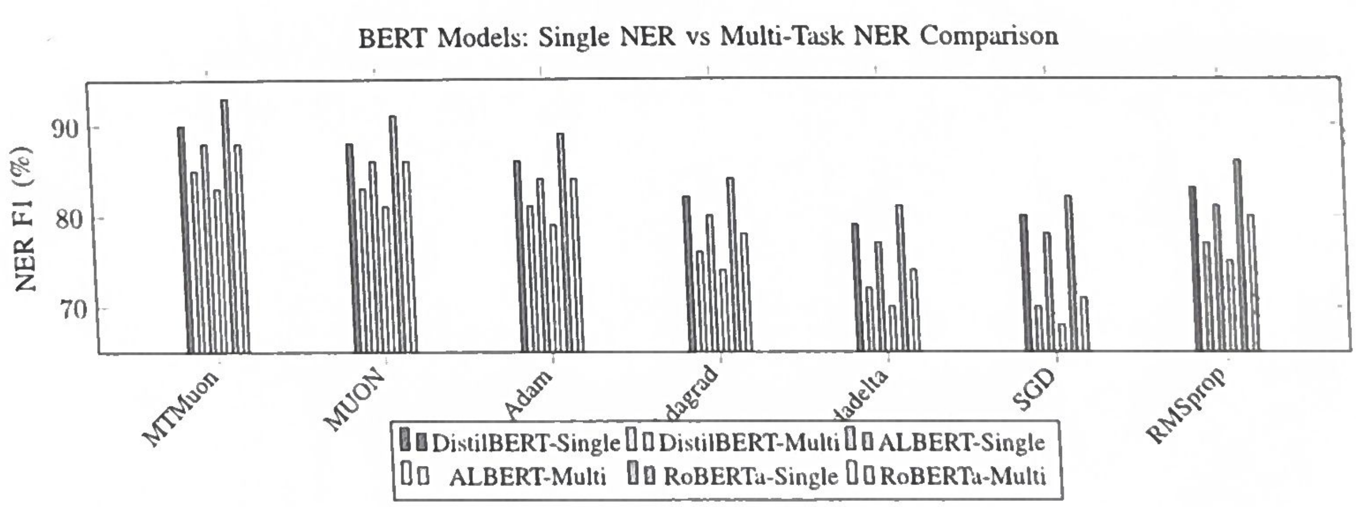

Fig. 17. BERT Models - Single vs Multi-Task Performance Degradation